

Typology, Language Contact, and Corpus Languages

A Unifying Approach

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WS The Typology of Contact-Induced Changes in Morphosyntax
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Purpose of this Panel & Talk

1. Convince you that typologists, contact linguists, historical linguists and language specialists need to cooperate more closely – **OBVIOUSLY**.
2. Lay out the purpose, advantages, and challenges of this kind of collaboration (using morphosyntactic alignment as an example).

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Structure

Challenges of Contact Linguistics

Contact & Typology

Changes in Morphosyntactic Alignment

Typology of Contact-induced Language Change

Danger!



Studying Contact

A typical (non-theoretical) language contact study presents a

- ▶ **synchronic** description and/or analysis of a language (feature) in two or more languages and/or
- ▶ **diachronic** explanation of a particular development (borrowing, copying, *etc.*) in one ore more language(s).

Focusing on the **diachronic** dimension and ruling out internal developments (POPLACK AND LEVEY 2010), such a study seeks to establish:

WHAT has happened **WHERE** and **WHEN** between **WHO** and under **WHAT** circumstances.

Challenges of Contact Studies

Especially in **historical** languages & those with no or a recent written tradition, answers to these questions are difficult to come by.

*[I]n order to make real progress in contact linguistics, we need to examine cases where we have a good understanding of the changes that have occurred in the [copying language] (i.e., of its structure both **before and after** copying) and a good understanding of the [model language] at the time that copying took place. We also need reliable information about the **sociolinguistic circumstances** of contact-information that is independent of the linguistic data.* (Ross 2019:124)

The **extralinguistic** dimension of the information required makes this challenging for some languages (e.g. Greek and Anatolian, cf. BIANCONI 2019; Parthian and Armenian, cf. MEYER 2022) and near impossible for others (e.g. languages of Australia, Oceania, South America).

Mitigation

Barring time travel or the discovery of new documents, this challenge can be mitigated by, *inter alia*,

- ▶ **comparative evidence:** similar changes have happened under similar circumstances in other languages;
- ▶ **typological data *e contrario*:** a particular change or set of features is rare or improbable.

In practice, such data collections often take the form of:

- ▶ overview papers or books (e.g. BEREZ-KROEKER ET AL. 2016 on the Americas; GARDANI 2019 on morphology);
- ▶ studies focussing on a particular feature, including a contact angle (e.g. ZÚÑIGA 2018 on morphosyntactic alignment);
- ▶ or large databases such as WALS.

Typology ≠ Typology

(The use of) Typology is not unambiguous for language contact studies:

- ▶ typology as **comparative evidence**;
- ▶ typology as **constraint against borrowing** (overview: MEAKINS 2021; a different perspective: MEYER 2019);
- ▶ typology **of contact** – **WHAT** is attested **WHERE** and under **WHICH** circumstances?

The third aspect is as yet underdocumented.

Why develop a typology of contact?

Typology as precedent:

Traditional historical methodology in linguistics is so heavily biased in favor of internal causation that the absence of proof of [contact-induced] interference might be thought to be sufficient evidence for internal causation. (THOMASON 1980:362)

Typology for better understanding:

[T]he social relations between the two speech communities, not the structures of their languages, determine the direction and even the extent of interference. (THOMASON 2008:53)

Elements of Contact Typology

For any one feature under scrutiny, these are the data ideally required:

- ▶ model language,
- ▶ copying language,
- ▶ geography (map representation),
- ▶ realisation of copied feature,
- ▶ time depth (of contact),
- ▶ time of copying (if available),
- ▶ sociolinguistic data (if available),
- ▶ references to the literature.

Map representation allows for first-glance insights. The other data points help elucidating whether a particular change is linked to, e.g., particular areal, time, or sociolinguistic variables.

Example: Morphosyntactic Alignment

Choice:

- ▶ closed set of feature realisations:
 - ▶ NOM-ERG ($S=A \neq O$)
 - ▶ ERG-ABS ($S=O \neq A$)
 - ▶ TRI ($S \neq A \neq O$)
 - ▶ NTR ($S=A=O$)
 - ▶ TRS ($S \neq A=O$)
- ▶ add: TSA or NP split variants
- ▶ exclude: semantic alignment changes
(e.g. agentive patterns in Tlingit ← Haida or Atakapa ← Yuki, cf. MITHUN 2008)

Challenges:

- ▶ Literature very disparate, varying degrees of detail
- ▶ Degree of certainty
- ▶ Circumstances of contact (socio-cultural) not always clear

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Some Data

Copying language	Model language	Type	References
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Light Warlpiri	Aus. English	EA→NA	BAVIN AND SHOPEN (1985)
Ch'olan	Yucatec	EA→SEA	LAW (2014); LAW ET AL. (2006)
Tanahu-Magar	Nepali	EA→SEA	NOONAN (2003)
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Cl. Armenian	Parthian	NA→SEA	MEYER (2017)
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A Map



Issues I

Mixed Languages

- ▶ Do we treat mixed languages in the same manner as non-mixed languages?

Material borrowing

- ▶ Where matter replication may be said to **cause** pattern replication, do we need to take this into account?

Numbers

- ▶ How many speakers need to effect a change for us to take it into account?

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Issues II

Categorisation (ex. Cl. Armenian)

proto-Arm.: NOM-ACC
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pre-literary: TSA split ERG-ABS
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classical: split TRI
↓ (cross-system harmonisation)
later: NOM-ACC

- ▶ Which stage of the language should be counted?

Data

- ▶ Some features (e.g. morphosyntactic alignment) are copied less commonly than others.
- ▶ Historical linguistic and socio-linguistic data are not available for all languages.

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What we need

Typology of Contact-induced Language Change (TypoCLaC)

(Suggestions for better acronyms welcome!)

- ▶ An online database collecting data, references, and analyses of features & changed realisations induced by contact
- ▶ modelled on WALS
and built on the Cross-Linguistic Linked Data (CLLD) platform developed by the MPI-EVA Leipzig
- ▶ collection of (initially) a limited number of salient features (in terms of language contact) in as many languages as available
- ▶ brief description of contact situation for each language n-tuple
- ▶ brief description of each feature realisation and change per contact situation
- ▶ cross-linguistic analysis of contact-induced changes → types
- ▶ integration & cooperation with other related projects/databases (e.g. AUTOTYP)

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Summary

- ▶ An open-access, collaborative, interactive, multi-feature and multi-source database of contact-induced language change is a desideratum.
- ▶ It would serve both as corroborative background information of existing changes ...
- ▶ ... and aid in the ‘discovery’ of new correlations, e.g. areal or featural.
- ▶ It would use existing, proven, and well-documented technological frameworks (e.g. the MPI’s CLLD).
- ▶ It would be dynamic, extendable, and open to external input.
- ▶ It requires the collaboration of language and area experts.

Thank you for listening!



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